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Will sustainable cooking gain a toehold?

As shortage in supply of LPG affects commercial kitchens, an enterprise working in that space with units in R.A. Puram and Semmancherry and a business promoting sale of traditional cookware with outlets at ECR and R.A. Puram weigh in on this question

PRINCE FREDERICK

Solutions that are sustainable in the long run and dependable in all seasons but requiring modifications in processes and behaviours in the short term will be ignored as long as solutions, easier but unreliable in some situations and even harmful in some others, are readily on tap. When that free-flowing tap suddenly settles to a trickle, sustainable solutions might get a toehold.

Currently, sustainable cooking solutions are gaining a toehold in commercial kitchens. Between jittery fingers, they are twirling various options that can do without the LPG cylinder. Some of these kitchens might be taking time out, but backstage they could be exploring sustainable cooking options.

The Semmancherry unit of Dabbakaran recently put out a note for its “Dear Dabbakaran Family” that “due to the ongoing crisis in commercial LPG cylinder supply, we are unable to source new cylinders. We deeply regret to inform you that we will not be able to supply food from 12th March, 2026 until this issue is resolved.

We are looking out for other alternative options to resolve the issue. We assure you that we will resume our services as early as possible.”

What pops out at any reader of this communication (it should, if it does not) is “other al-



Wood-fired mud stove in a pastoral setting in India. Sleek and fancy wood-fired stoves are also being offered as an option in modern domestic kitchen systems. Will commercial kitchens now adopt this form of sustainability at scale? GETTY IMAGES

ternative options”.

When *The Hindu Downtown* got in touch with a team member of Dabbakaran, it is obvious that behind the temporarily lowered shutters of its Semmancherry unit, the business which caters meals for subscribers is not leaving any stone (actually, ‘any wood’ or ‘food waste’) unturned in cranking up the services quickly and preventing a stretched lull.

The team member observes they are considering the option of cooking with wood, minimal wood, on a blower-assisted stove.

The team member pulls out another option that is under study: zero-waste cooking. Turning food waste into gas, popularly known as biogas.

The Semmancherry unit caters for 500 members, many of whom are in the sixty-plus age bracket, and depend heavily on this service (breakfast, lunch and dinner), hence the desperate attempts to kickstart it with alternative cooking methods, says the team member. Dabbakaran continues to run its kitchen in R.A. Puram with a trimmed-down menu; this kitchen serves around 900 meals (lunch and dinner) every day.

Traditional cookware in focus

Kayal Sriram runs an eponymous enterprise, Essential Traditions by Kayal, that sells traditional iron, cast-iron, soapstone and brass cookware and serveware from two physical outlets, one on ECR and the other at R.A. Puram,

and online. Domestic kitchens have constituted the business’s strong base; but the current crisis seems bent on extending the business into the commercial kitchen, as the movement in that direction has already happened, precisely one month before this crisis showed up on the horizon.

Kayal notes the foray one month ago into serving commercial kitchens had to do with “serving”, that is sale of serveware. Now, following the events of the last few days, the focus has widened to include cookware.

Kayal points out that the efforts would be directed towards scaling traditional cookware, making them more capacious: large-sized cookware. Among the traditional cookware that are

likely to gain traction after the recent turn of events, Kayal names wood-fired stoves, because they are already leaving their “flavour” behind in modern kitchens. She explains that modern kitchens are incorporating wood-fired stoves as an option.

She is also witnessing an interest in *kumuti adupu* (charcoal stoves) as a result of the LPG crisis. While she has no problem with these being used in domestic settings, she

considers huge charcoal stoves infeasible, even inadvisable (given their capacity for pollution when used at scale) in commercial kitchens. In certain parts of the country, particularly the NCR region, a ban on the use of these stoves in commercial kitchens are firmly in place.

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Footbridge near Kasturba Nagar MRTS sought

T.S. ATUL SWAMINATHAN

With the new flyover at Madhya Kailash making for more fluid vehicular movement, would a foot overbridge near VHS Hospital and Kasturba Nagar MRTS station be in order?

A section of pedestrians hitting this section think it is, explaining that this section lacks speed calming measures.

At Indira Nagar and Thiruvannamiyur, near the MRTS stations FOBs have been provided by Tamil Nadu Road Development Corporation. There are many educational institutions and companies near the Madhya Kailash section including Institute of Leather Technology, Institute of Printing Technology, Dr. Dharmambal Government Polytechnic College for Women, Roja Muthaiah Research Library, Asian College of Journalism, M S Swaminathan Research Foundation, the Institute of Textile Technology, Institute of Printing Technol-



Wrong side driving is common outside the Kasturba Nagar station on Rajiv Gandhi Salai, posing a risk to pedestrians. PHOTO: SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT

ogy, Tidel Park and Ramanujam Tech Park.

K. Rekha Kanakasabapathy, a pedestrian, says an FOB will help those studying at Central Polytechnic College, V. H. S., M. A. Chidambaram School and College of Nursing.

Currently, people cross this section by using any available gaps in the median.

"An FOB should be constructed at the end of Madhya Kailash overpass," says Rekha.

Outside Kasturba Nagar railway station, zebra crossing lines have been painted, but rumblers are also needed, says V. George, a senior citizen and a pedestrian.

Nine achievers from Neelankarai

As part of its golden jubilee year, SKNRWAN conducted an awareness programme for women working as domestic help. It also honoured nine women residents of the neighbourhood

Nine distinguished women residents of Sri Kapaleeswarar Nagar in Neelankarai, who have rendered dedicated service in various fields were honoured with the "SKN Golden Women Awards - 2026" on the occasion of Women's Day.

Organised by Sri Kapaleeswarar Nagar Residents Welfare Association (SKNRWAN) as part of its Golden Jubilee Year celebrations, the event also saw a community welfare awareness programme for women working as domestic help in the neighbourhood.

The awards were presented by former High Court Judges M. Jaichandren (ret'd.) and G. M. Akbarali (ret'd.).

The women achievers are: SKN Lifetime Inspiration Award - Dr. Vijaya-lakshmy; SKN Social Impact Award - Sandhya Jaichandren; SKN Environmental Responsibility Award - Nagasaila; SKN Women Entrepreneurship Excellence Award -



Sivakami Ramesh; SKN Education & Knowledge Excellence Award - S. Sasi-kala Ashok; SKN Healthcare & Wellness Service Award - Dr. Valli Sathya-moorthy; SKN Cultural Heritage & Arts Award - Muthu Gnanam; SKN Woman of Excellence Award - N. Marxia Gandhi; and SKN Community Leadership Award - Jayalakshmi Rajagopal.

Awareness session

"Clean Hands - Clean House - Clean Nagar," a special health and hygiene awareness programme, was organised for domestic help. More than 100 of them, representing households across 20 streets of Sri Kapaleeswarar Nagar participated

in the programme. Participants were presented with saris, stainless steel utility boxes, and herbal hand wash. Vasan Eye Care Hospital supported the initiative by providing free eye check-up coupons and healthcare service coupons worth ₹2,000 for the participants and their family members, said a release. Representatives from Bank of Maharashtra also addressed the gathering and created awareness about the importance of savings, banking facilities, and financial inclusion for domestic help. The event also featured street theatre performances and cultural programmes highlighting the importance of women's rights, equality, and empowerment, added the release.

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Images include bovine presence on median at Melakottaiyur; the signal near Crescent College in Vandalur; Kolapakkam junction; and a view of the New Vandalur Flyover. PHOTOS: PRINCE FREDERICK

Lack of lighting, except for a scatter of a pathetically few high-mast lamps, and a ridiculously low median make Vandalur-Kelambakkam Road one of the deadliest thoroughfares in Chennai



Motorists drive 'blindfolded' on major corridor

PRINCE FREDERICK

Manga legend Naruto Uzumaki's heroics include his adroit dodging of antagonist Madara's Light Fang. Imagine a parallel universe called Vandalur-Kelambakkam Road directing its Dark Fang at Naruto: this weapon is the exact opposite of Madara's, pitch darkness replacing blinding light, but it is just as deadly, if not more. How Naruto would fare on this "pitch-dark" road is probably open to debate, that is, among non-fans. But no discussion is warranted where regular motorists are concerned; they are bound to struggle navigating the road at night.

Expect a pat and damning word about the road's lighting quotient from the traffic police personnel attached to the Kilambakkam station that man the junction of GST Road and Vandalur-Kelambakkam Road,



going by what this writer heard from one of them recently: "No lights for twenty kilometres!" For factual accuracy, around 23 kilometres. That statement ignores the fact that high-mast lamps have been planted in the median at certain key junctions (examples include Kolapakkam and Kandigai) and around educational institu-

tions (examples include Tagore Engineering College, Sri Balaji Polytechnic College, Ramanujar Engineering College and Sri Balaji Arts and Science College). But these high-mast lights (some not so high) are few in number, some are only partly functional; and collectively, they cannot undo that damning remark. For all practical

purposes, it is a road plunged in darkness.

Median compounds matters

What gives the poor lighting on the road its barbed-wire deadliness is a structural design element on the ground: the low median. The median (maintained well by VIT) is so low that even a gnat can put all its six legs on it in one gentle heave, its wings kept folded in a resting state. Do not parse that idea; that is hyperbole, but you get the point. Except for a 400-metre stretch in Vengambakkam where a high median exists, Vandalur-Kelambakkam Road has a dangerously low median that leaks bipeds (human bipeds) quadrupeds (stray cattle), often taking motorists by round-eyed surprise. Dedicated road-crossings become a joke when every point of the median can be forded with the least of efforts.

Another deadly dimension: motorists on this road seem to be in the kind of hurry one witnesses in

a run chase in a high-scoring T20 match. In front of B.S. Abdur Rahman Crescent Institute of Science and Technology in Vandalur, a signal is operated, the support staff at the college operating the "levers" around an hour in the morning when students walk in, and for a similar duration in the evening when the students walk out. The ground staff points out despite the signals, they have to wait outside and put out their hands to stop motorists for the students to cross the road.

Dawn presages the day

As if to presage the poor lighting on Vandalur-Kelambakkam Road, a majority of the lamps on what is called the New Vandalur Bridge arching over the section of GST Road that nuzzles against Vandalur-Kelambakkam Road shirk work. And hard by, at the toe of Vandalur-Kelambakkam Road, a high-mast lamp functions with a skeletal staff, barring two, the lights are on indefinite medical leave.



'Heavy vehicles should not ply during peak hours'

Following a fatal accident on Nookampalayam Main Road recently, Federation of Perumbakkam Residents' Welfare Associations has submitted a list of necessary safety measures to the police



The Federation of Perumbakkam Residents' Welfare Associations has submitted a petition to the Inspector of Police, Traffic, Medavakkam and the Tambaram City Police Commissionerate outlining measures to prevent accidents.

Recently, a woman and her daughter were run over by a heavy vehicle on Nookampalayam Main Road.

The woman and her daughter were on the way to school.

K. Sarangadass, the federation secretary, says, "Heavy vehicles must be prevented from plying on Nookampalayam Road in Perumbakkam during rush hour. There must be a ban between 7 and 9 a.m. and from 3 p.m. to 5 p.m."

Police personnel should be deployed to curb speeding; and parking of vehicles along the road should be prohibited.

The width of the road should be increased to 60 feet, medians should be installed, and all encroachments should be removed to ensure a safe commute, say residents.

Text: T.S. Atul Swaminathan

Representational picture.
PHOTO: R. RAVINDRAN

Footwear for senior citizens

Footcares sells footwear that are made of soft polymer. According to a press release, the following are some of the features of Footcares products: even distribution of plantar pressure, reduced friction in the feet, better shock absorption, and relief for foot pain. The products are suitable for senior citizens and diabetic patients, adds the release.

These are corrective footwear for corns, calluses, warts, heel pain, heel cracks and related issues, adds the release. The store is run by Saraswathi Priya Murugan. The store is located at No.7, First Main Road, Kasturba Nagar, Adyar. It is open from Monday to Saturday. Time: 10 a.m. to 8 p.m. Phone: 7010289912 / 9941007521

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READERS WRITE

Words to live by, now

The LPG scarcity might not have affected supply of domestic LPG cylinders, but Kamla Ravikumar, a resident of Kalakshetra Colony in Adyar, believes this crisis should be a wake-up call for everyone, and it does not hurt to be careful with LPG use

At any other point in human history, the following 'Words To Live By' listicle would have been brushed aside as kibitzing. With every filled gas cylinder now worth its weight in gold, mention of the word commands an automatic audience, not to mention tips to conserve it. Here is Kamla Ravikumar, a long-time resident of Kalakshetra Colony and a member of Kalakshetra Colony Welfare Association (KCWA), pointing out how to be frugal with the use of the gas cylinder.

1. You have been living with a keyhole view of the electric kettle's potential; time to broaden your thinking and give that electric kettle today those portfolios of tea and coffee making in addition to its regular one, water boiling.

2. If you thought OPOS Dis-

hes (One Pot One Shot) are gimmicky, suspend that thought now, till the cloud over supply of LPG cylinders passes.

3. Take the wraps off that induction stove that came as a freebie with that jewellery purchase; it can come in handy now for dishes that take longer to cook. And for heaven's sake, use that electric cooker for cooking rice.

4. Avoid organising dinner parties at your home, even at gun point. But if you cannot wriggle out of it, suggest a pot luck dinner. Either they agree and the LPG spend is distributed; or they pull out, one by one. Either way, you win.

5. Avoid like the plague vegetables that take time to cook. Beetroot should be anathema to you in these times.

6. If you already do not have one, order an induction stove

before #inductionstoveshortage begins to compete with #gascylindershortage. Orders are already flying thick and fast, and so hurry.



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SHARON JESSICA MICHAEL

Anyone with normal vision would need just a quarter of a glance to distinguish a ₹50 note from a ₹500 note. For a visually impaired individual, any effort in that direction would require dependence on others. The Tamil Nadu state branch of National Association for the Blind (NAB) is seeking to cut out that dependence by distributing “Vision Wallets” to visually impaired individuals. On March 13, at its office in Kodungaiyur, it distributed these Vision Wallets to 15 visually impaired women, to mark International Women’s Day. The 15 are part of a batch of 250 visually impaired individuals across Tamil Nadu to receive this assistive device. The Vision Wallets are sponsored by Synamedia India Pvt. Ltd., Tharamani; Reachem Laboratory Chemicals Pvt. Ltd.; and the Rotaract Clubs. Applications would open after this batch of 250 are served.

What is a Vision Wallet anyway? Developed by H Vision India Pvt. Ltd., the device allows users to instantly identify currency denominations and detect counterfeit notes without relying on a smartphone or internet connectivity. It resembles a conventional men’s wallet fitted with a compact electronic module. Embedded sensors detect the currency note and relay the denomination through audio output in Hindi and English. Specially designed grooves guide the note into position from any corner, enabling the sensors to read it accurately and announce the value almost instantly without internet connectivity. The device came to NAB’s attention after one of the organisation’s secretaries encountered it at an assistive technology exhibition organised by Vellore Institute of Technology. Dipti Bhatia, CEO of NAB’s Tamil Nadu branch, says it was obvious to them that it offered a practical solution. “Many people think visually impaired persons can simply use smartphones or Google Pay,” she observes. “But not everyone owns a smartphone or is comfortable using one. Even existing apps require scanning and waiting, and sometimes the voice output is too soft or the scan fails. The wallet offers a simple and quick hands-on solution.”

The priority list

The organisation received more than 250 applications from across the State. However, limited funding meant only a small number of wallets could be distributed in the first phase. Beneficiaries were selected based on income: those earning less than ₹2 lakh annually received the device free of cost;



A wallet with ‘eyes’

National Association for the Blind — Tamil Nadu has launched an initiative to distribute Vision Wallets to visually impaired individuals with an event organised at its office in Chennai on March 13. The assistive device spells out the denomination of a currency note



Snapshots of the event at NAB’s Chennai office; and the Vision Wallet. PHOTOS: SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT

A word from the beneficiaries

Mary from Pallikaranai earns her livelihood through chair re-caning. Running a business is tough, doing so as a visually challenged person, tougher still. The initiative by the Tamil Nadu branch of the National Association for the Blind (NAB), has taken one worry off her table. “Now I can confidently say that I am

giving the correct amount without worrying about being cheated,” says Mary.

Another beneficiary, Krithika, a first-year student of Madras Christian College, says this Vision Wallet would put an end to a dependence while shopping: “asking the person next to me about the denomination of the currency I was giving”.

those earning between ₹2 lakh and ₹5 lakh paid a nominal contribution of ₹500; and those earning above ₹5 lakh are expected to purchase it independently. The device carries an approximate market price of ₹3,600. Priority was also given to students and individuals who frequently handle cash such as street vendors, small traders and others whose livelihoods depend on regular cash transactions.

The initiative was spearheaded by Vikas, honorary secretary of the NAB Tamil Nadu branch. After testing it, he recognised its practicality immediately. “When I placed currency notes on the device, I found it to be very useful and practical,” he said. The initiative also hit an early setback when an NGO that had initially planned to supply the wallets withdrew from the programme, by which point hundreds had already applied. “We felt we could not abandon them because the wallet could significantly improve their independence,” said Vikas. The organisation turned to donors and supporters to sustain the project.

The origin story

The Vision Wallet itself originated from a moment of observation. In 2019, while pursuing product design, founder of H Vision India Pvt. Ltd., Hasin Vaidya visited the Blind People’s Association in Ahmedabad and noticed a visually impaired man struggling to identify a ₹10 note after buying tea. “To make a payment of ten rupees, the person took around four to five minutes,” he recalled. “Even after giving the note, he asked the tea seller to confirm if it was a ₹10 note.” That moment led Hasin to rethink the wallet entirely. “I thought of making the wallet itself smart,” he said. “In the same wallet where they keep their currency notes and documents, they should also be able to identify the notes.” User feedback shaped several improvements. Battery life extended from 1.5 days to two days to nearly a month, with only an hour of charging required. The automatic power feature was replaced with a manual on-off switch, allowing users to activate the device only when needed. Some users asked for coin identification but it was not implemented because it was technically impractical. After years of development, the company launched its first production batch in 2024 and began collaborating with NGOs across India. Users who can afford the device can buy it directly online from the manufacturer, at hvision.in. NAB welcomes donors to support their initiative to distribute the device to visually impaired individuals. Donors can sponsor the cost of three or five wallets. NAB can be contacted at 9840917314.

The Rotary Club of Madras Metro presented the 3rd Edition of the Spirit of India Awards 2026, a pan-India initiative dedicated to "Recognising the Unrecognised" – individuals who have made extraordinary contributions to society, often away from the public spotlight, on March 13 at Madras Management Association.

The event was graced by T. M. Veeraraghav, Executive Editor, NDTV, as the chief guest, and Rtn. Dr. Vijaya Bharathi Rangarajan, District Governor Elect, 2027 - 28 as the guest of honour.

The winners are: Chandana Sinha, Inspector, RPF (Guardian of Hope), Lucknow, for her exemplary service in protecting vulnerable children and ensuring safety and dignity within the railway ecosystem; Jagriti Mishra, animal activist from Delhi, recognised for her relentless dedication to animal welfare and advocacy for the protection and humane treatment of animals; P. Naveen Kumar, Champion of Dignity from Erode, was acknowledged for his inspiring work in em-

Recognising the *Unrecognised*

The third edition of Rotary Club of Madras Metro's Spirit of India Awards honoured four individuals from four cities



▼ The awardees seen with Veeraraghav, Executive Editor, NDTV (3rd from left); Dr. Vijaya Bharathi Rangarajan (3rd from right); Club president Mahesh Krishna (2nd from right); Club Secretary Binny Rajkumar (extreme right); Suresh Jain (2nd from left) and Ram Kumar P T (extreme left)

powering communities and upholding human dignity through social initiatives; and Dr. Suneela Kumar Hebba - Healing Beyond Boundaries, Bengaluru, for his compassionate medical service and commitment to providing health-

care that reaches beyond conventional limits.

The Spirit of India Awards initiative by the Rotary Club of Madras Metro aims to spotlight unsung heroes across India whose courage, compassion, and com-

mitment make a meaningful difference in society, said a release.

Through this platform, the club continues its mission of promoting humanitarian values and encouraging individuals who work tirelessly for the welfare of others

without seeking recognition.

The president of the club A. S. Mahesh Krishna expressed that these awards serve as a reminder that true heroes often work silently, driven only by the spirit of service and humanity.



Turning the Pages on Women's Day

The Bookworms Club, the literary arm of FOMRRA, held its 7th meeting on March 8 at Godrej Azure Apartments in Padur

HARSHA KODA

The gathering also coincided with the 20th OMR Book Swap, a movement that celebrates giving stories a second life. Instead of letting books gather dust on shelves or drift toward landfills, readers exchanged them for unread titles from other collections.

More than 100 books found new homes, thanks to the efforts of Anitha and the volunteers of Godrej Azure Apartments. The resident library also refreshed its shelves with new additions from the Book Swap event.

OMR's budding writer Siddhartha Pappala shared his journey from being a hobby writer to becoming a published author, in con-

versation with Ranjit Narayanan. His second book, You, Me and the So-Called Stupid Love, was featured in this edition.

The book is a collection of poetic conversations between two people in love, tracing their journey of togetherness through themes such as lust, toxicity, weirdness, loss, pain, anger, and moments that linger forever.

Book 'breakdown'

Moderated by OMR author Sujatha Rengachari, the Bookworms group delved into the 2002 Booker Prize-winning novel Life of Pi. The discussion sparked lively debate and diverse interpretations.

Many readers felt the book was a challenging

read, yet widely praised it for its imagination, philosophical depth, and emotional impact. The famous ending where Pi presents two versions of the story and asks the listener which one they prefer was widely regarded as thought-provoking and powerful.

Together, the Book Swap, author interaction, and literary discussion made the Women's Day gathering a celebration of stories, voices, and the shared joy of reading.

(Harsha Koda is co-founder of FOMRRA)

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A tribute to women of all generations

Elementary and lower secondary children of Bodhana & Learning Tree Montessori recently presented “Sivagangaiyin Seetram”, a Tamil dance drama at BK Auditorium, Kalakshetra Foundation to observe Women’s Day. This powerful performance was a fitting tribute to women of all generations, says a press release, on the eve of Women’s Day. Udaya Padai’s stunts, as performed by the students, were a highlight. “It was an ambitious project with 60 children in the cast working for four months,” says Principal Uma Sankaran.



ProNutramax introduces two brands

ProNutramax, a health drink company, has launched two brands: ‘Pro Nutra Kidz’ for the mind and body, and ‘Authentic Natural Indian (ANI)’, aimed at preserving traditional Indian cooking.

Pro Nutra Kidz comes in two flavours: classic vanilla and rich chocolate, designed to support strong bones, boost immunity and provide sustained energy.

ANI offers a variety of spices and instant mixes, including ‘idli podi,’ ‘rasam,’ ‘sambar,’ ‘puliyocharai,’ and ‘rava idli’ mixes.

Latha Dubay, founder of ProNutramax, said, “Today’s new-generation parents often find it hard to balance their kids’ hectic school schedules with proper nutrition, while also trying to keep the authentic flavours of traditional home cooking.

Understanding this, ProNutramax has combined science-backed nutrition with the trusted taste of the past to bring back parent-approved nutrition to every family’s table, said a release.

For details, contact 95009 10040 98402 97720. Website : <https://pronutramax.com/>

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